

Quartz in Coal

By: Jacob Dylan

Chapter 1: A Chunk of Winter's Tempest

THIS MOUNTAIN...

The mountain is the valley,
and the distance between—
their dance.

Winter's warning says: seek refuge and wait. But there is solace in the cold
that shivers the souls of our forebears.

Spring's renewal comes
as the seasons breathe.

Is it not here now?

And yet the eternal spring
comes for us all.

So is spring not winter?

And mountain not valley?

Thus Annwn is neither season nor elevation,
but a song—

sung and danced
in the space between.

Do not ask for whom the birds sing;
they sing for thee.

THE WOODS...

There's a stillness in the woods when you listen,
and that stillness turns to shouts—
like the land screams, just wanting to be heard.

While the deer linger
and the woodpecker sings,
the bobcat watches in the dark—
and there is no danger from it
when you live in its world,
though it does see.

Those eyes blink when the light hits right.
And in the morning you'll find doe skulls and kind,
quartz in anthracite, droppings and prints.
January's cold is unforgiving—but it gives
when you let the woods breathe and sit.

FAIRMONT...

Four inches of snow—and lit up a smoke
on a January night near the park.

The place was the green,
and the music could be seen
as the door shut behind me
and I stepped out.

But the door opened again,
and you followed me out—

and that's a sight that I'll never unsee. Phosphorescent glow and ember overtone
of that long hair I still hold.
And we smoked that smoke,
and I don't remember what was said—
but I'll never forget that feeling.
It still rattles in my head,
though the feeling's been long dead,
and I'm grateful to have witnessed your dream.

THE CREEK...

Sticks versus rocks—who do ya think would win?
Best one to throw 'em and crack the other's skin.
And we'd bleed and scream,
and finally jump in—
and nothing's as cold as the creek
on a summer night,
and nothing made you feel more alive.
Don't be there alone
as the moonlight shone,
and the wolves will sing in delight.

ALCHEMY...

Water to wine—or something divine.
A gift given, and so you'll receive. The witches make pitches

in pots in the kitchen,
and howl at the moon's coming wane.
Don't look too long,
and don't overstay the course—
or long you might end up on stay.
Moons, creeks, and radiators,
dine-ins and movie theaters—
the coal keeps us warm in the wake.

Adjacent

To be near and to be seen—
Are we one or in between? I'd do it much better a third time,
love bombing and sobbing
for a stranger's longing
to make things feel okay.
And what was missed was the time
I could have had while you were mine.
Instead, I shot for the sky.
To be adjacent to one
was all that was spun,
and that was more than okay.

WHO STAYS...

Some birds stay and some leave, migrating winters

or hunker in trees.

Some sing and some fly high above,

some wait and some dine,

some hunt and some die—

all just birds of a feather,

looking for respite.

Chapter 2: Bits of Memory

13

17 years ago... we did partake

in human ritual of love coming awake. And when I think about it now,

it seems so wrong for such young souls

to think no wrong of it.

And that summer was magic;

we swam in the static

and we ran from the hordes

of young men

just wanting to be adored by the magic of yours

that you gave to me at no cost.

I'll always be with you—when we were young, true,

and barely 13.

Icy When the rain falls after a midwinter's snow,

it ices over and

down we go, we go, we go—

faster and faster and faster indeed.

Don't put your hands down

or they'll get cut and they'll bleed.

The speed on that slope like a penguin bobsledder,

the inevitable prickles at the bottom that shredded,

and an explanation to parents

of why you need stitches—

What the hell did you do?

You broke early with hand rails—

you just gotta slide through.

Hate a Dead Man

You ever hate a dead man for the pain they caused?

The lingering feeling of not getting yours before they lost

their life's breath and soul now—

but not at your own toll.

You'll only spit on their hollowed ground.

Spiting a ghost in the pain unseen,

damning their family and wishing they could get a glean

of what their kin did to me or mine.

You took so much and I didn't get mine.

At least a sucker punch would maybe have been fine.

I'll piss on you in my dream.

You can curse a dead man all that you want—it doesn't change his rot or the price.

Anger and vitriol, pain lingers and boils;
some debts just don't go away.

Best Bowl

Christmas Eve punches in the gut.

I spent a day with my family and I loved it,
but that was enough.

And as the midnight struck from eve to Christmas Day,
I text you for a dime bag and thought, no way.

I went over to that raggedy apartment on the Perk...

no one was there but you and your cocky smirk, seemed to hide the loneliness of yours you felt
inside

to not have Christmas Eve or Christmas Day with family
beside.

And you asked me if I wanted to smoke and chill,
and I didn't really,
but my heart told me I will.

It don't usually snow on Christmas Eve,
but that one I'm glad time ain't deceive
a memory in the snow...

The last I'd see of you and your kind—
the dope boys and dealers
and some others time hasn't enshrined.

You all passed at the same time,
months after that midnight mass,
in moonlight of snow falling and bubbling glass

and loss of young lives gone too soon. Glad I got to spend that Christmas Eve with you.

Breaking a Friend's Heart

In the fourth grade we started to know each other well.

I was always in my head and you freed me from my shell.

Made me feel like a part—

at least when you'd talk to me like the human in everyone
that you make them see.

And your momma was always right

and your dad always true,

and your family let me in because you did too.

Do what's right and you'll be repaid in kind—a break from the yelling that I saw in mine.

At least that's what I saw:

a family whole, and me included.

When I was with you, you shared it

and it made me feel brand new.

You cared and you never hid,

and you called me out on my shit,

and I pushed you and punched

so I'd always have an exit.

And I ran and I ran when the going got tough,

and you never scoured me or got angry...

you just said it must be tough.

And I don't know much about love or unrequitedness,

but if I do, it's because you showed me it. The busy kitchen and wife and good, good times I know that

you have

with kids and friendships and care that you always gave.

And I miss you like crazy,

and I'm so proud of who you became.

Your voice always lingers—

c'mon man, come back inside,

there's food and drink, we're having a good time.

Chapter 3: Love

Innocence

To take a child's wit—they're spry and their play, their longing for recess or school the next day, the feeling of summer and winter at once,

their place in a place and their heart all at once.

I don't know what would compel

something like that

from a deep twisted well—

and emotions, in fact,

or human compulsions and pride, envy, or joy—

but words can't be unspoken and youth can't be retoyed.

It sits in the back of a fragmented head.

One person can't be responsible for a life misled.

Don't mean you don't want to give them that—

an explanation or reason—but even that lacks.

'Cause you know that words can't be unspoken,
and crises of oneself or others' devotion.

So sit with it now and when you were a kid, and don't blame no one but yourself for the
misshaped grid

of life went left and left and then right—

but two more lefts too and right, oh it might—

or just... get out of that maze and go on back to work the
next day,

and don't speak of the evil that took childhood away.

Birds That Don't See

It's so cold here and I'm missing you dearly.

The silence is like when you used to shut down
in sadness or protection when I'd let my anger out.

I never knew what to do with the patterns
and cycles that became of you.

I tried to escape by building a castle that only I could relate—
of numbers and structures and things I'd inflate.

But you never would have come in.

In anything I made, you didn't like to see me not dim.

So I guess that's what I'm missing:

the time we used to pretend

that one day we'd be better

and we'd let each other begin.

But disparate causes and virtues and ways to behave,
and feelings and emotions we'll take to the grave,

and vices and spices and feast for a king and queen...

I missed you since I met you...

it was a fever dream.

But that's what was broken:

the acknowledgement that we don't see each other for where each other's at.

That we satiated and relegated and pickled anew

every night the booze or drugs or the emotions broke

through.

Disdain and resentment for each other was what we

learned...

solving maybe, or at least being happy the other's unearned

—

finding a better life.

I'll still miss you always and carry you in these memories

of your flannels I tarnished and your words that cut through

my skin.

I always made you lose and you never let me win;

that's a battle of lovers that could never begin.

Yet I still hear your laugh and Hank's bark and your scorn

across the imaginary southern line that's adorned in every way you are and everything that I am.

We hurt each other, but maybe made each other whole again.

So I'll think of you fondly, just no longer divine,

and forgive that you're human—

and so am I.

Tonight I'll sleep and probably dream again of you,
and tomorrow might be better and I'll see it through.
A new season of warmth to guide me in you,
trees that I'll plant and my mind to subdue.
I don't know who you are and you don't know me,
and that's why we always kept watching—
two birds who don't see.

Chapter 4: The Blues

My dad told me it takes five minutes to learn the blues—
a hand mute and two strings and some rhythm not to lose.
Then he told me it takes a lifetime to play
Heartbreaker and life learned the hard way.
And somewhere on Main in Manayunk, Sammy said,
“Boy, why your hands are shook?”
He said, “I think you might have a problem with booze.”
And I thought I was stolen from,
but said sometimes you play to lose.
And years and decades and time it does take—
hurting yourself and others in the wake
of goal posts keep moving from things not seen
to begging you to stay and not becoming a dream of a son, a brother, a friend who's been lost on
the way,
but someone to rely and someone to stay.
And it goes so much further down

than a gut rot and drown...

just slowly and slowly and painfully and ugly going down.

No matter how much you try, there's a set cost.

A shot for a shake and a life that is lost.

Love for a Child

And my momma didn't cry when I cussed out that nurse

and yelled and screamed in the car that should have been a

hearse,

and the doctor, he said, "We can't let him in

with BAC so high, this is medically grim. And his last drink was really six hours ago?

He's gonna be in for a rough one—the shadow people

know."

And my mom didn't cry—she just sat there and made sure

I didn't get kicked out, that they'd let me in with a cure.

And the days following, when I came back down to earth,

she talked on the phone every time I asked of her.

And more years and years and years of that

while others gave cold shoulder—

she just wanted to chat.

She never would let the demon inside,

the evil she knew her son not to be, shine.

She told me she loved always and no matter,

and I'd be dead without her—she was the stuff,

the emotions and faith and laughs in the way, the nonjudgmental love that never decayed.

A love for a child—I don't know it myself,
but it's the only reason I'm not on a shelf.

Chapter 5: Into the Woods

Low Country

I went to the islands for a place brand new
where beaches and food is on end—
five women and a tree stand
for every average-looking man.

The proportions brought me to you. In truth, I went to the water
'cause a woman said she had answer
on how to finally dry out,
rid myself of my demons and finally be whole again,
make the withdrawals scoff at the sand.

What I found was a mirage
of paradise lost.

If they're not taking the piss to your face,
it's probably on your back.

And then a bird who I could see—
and see she did to me,
though she had eyes for other feathers too.

I thought that a dry spell would give me a new well,
but just a life without grace and trying to fill. No matter how much I've run

or how much I hide,
a shadow follows me to no end.
And what I'm seeing and starting to believe
is that shadow has always been me.

Grace

Grace I've learned is an underserved gift,
from God above or person here and now.
We all are sinners, the good book delivers,
but what of God in this house?
Won't save you from pain or misfortune or lust,
so we need grace from strangers and people the same. If I am a sinner and Grace is my dinner,
then God is you at the table here now.

Chapter 6: Departure

Elen of Ways

As the waxing moon rose to be the last of winter,
I talked by a tree to my gone grandfather.
What I used to not know
is the paths these woods once had
for deer and travelers, pilgrims and those lost to the land.
That is when I felt Elen's weight on mine.
She came to me as women do—

a desire inside, a static in the air,
a heart and lower yearning for what it knows is new.

Something inside felt
the opposite of despair.

And that was the last night I spent in those woods.

And after I called, she answered with a shrill

I'll never say nor forget—

a way of speaking that is primal,
that only the earth can connect.

And now how can the streets of man look the same,
and the crowds in bars or city or congregation be such?

For I held the guardian of the ways, antlered horns in my
hands,

and saw the earth in her eyes—

Gaia's green eyes, did they shine.

And she did not feel like any woman I've ever known—unmoved and unchanged by the world's
other demise.

She took the gift and called,

but not in pain or thanks—

just a cycle of life and coming anew.

And now she'll never leave my dreams or side gaze of
thought—

I'll look all the same and see a fire run out.

These paths I may take, I'll know now the direction—

just not where I'm going,

other than to Elen and her ways.